Usage of “On” in French

On as informal “nous”

On is a personal subject pronoun which is synonymous with **nous, and** it is conjugated in third-person singular, i.e., same as il/ elle. It is used in speech, mostly in the informal tone.

Français	English
On va manger des sushis ce soir. **Nous** allons manger des sushis ce soir.	**We** will eat sushi tonight.
On prend le bus à 7 heures tous les matins. **Nous** prenons le bus à 7 heures tous les matins.	**We** take the bus at 7 AM every morning.
Désolé ! **On** n’a pas fait attention. Désolé ! **Nous** n’avons pas fait attention.	Sorry! **We** did not pay attention.
On n'est pas des amateurs. **Nous** ne sommes pas des amateurs.	**We** are not amateurs.

Note: While **On** is conjugated in the third-person singular, the adjectives, and subject attributes may agree with the implied subject of **On**.

As an Impersonal Neutral Subject

On can serve as a neutral generic subject and does not refer to one particular subject (an individual or a group of individuals). It translates to **one** and serves as a subject in sentences stating a general truth.

Français	English
On doit regarder dans les deux sens en traversant la rue.	**One** must look both ways when crossing the road.
Quand **on** mûrit, on revient vers soi-même.	When **one** matures, **one** returns to oneself.
On fait bien quand **on** fait des efforts dans quelque chose.	**One** does well when **one** puts effort into something.
On ne sait jamais.	**You never know.**
Moins **on** sait, plus **on** croit.	The less **one** knows, the more **one** believes.

As a group of people in general

On can refer to a larger group of people and is used to state general facts/tendencies.
It translates to: **“people”**, **“they”**, or **“one”.**

Français	English
En France, **on** mange beaucoup de baguettes.	In France, **people** eat a lot of baguettes. In France, **one** eats a lot of baguettes. In France, **they** eat a lot of baguettes.
On parle français au Québec.	**People** speak French in Quebec.
On dit que c'est un très bon film.	**They** say it's a very good film.
On est fous ici.	**People** are crazy here.
En Suède, **on** est très heureux.	In Sweden, **people** are very happy.

As “quelqu’un”

On can designate an undetermined subject when the subject is not known to the speaker, it is then equivalent to **“someone”**.

Français	English
On a laissé un colis pour vous.	**Someone** left a parcel for you.
On va venir voir ça.	**Someone** will come and take a look at this.
Il ne faut pas interrompre quand **on** parle.	Don’t interrupt when **someone** is speaking.
On doit s’occuper de nos enfants.	**Someone** has to look after our children.
On a dû entrer par la fenêtre.	**Someone** must’ve entered through the window.

Acting like a Passive Voice

On can also be equivalent to the English passive voice.

Français	English
On n’accepte pas les chèques.	Checks not accepted.
On l’a vu dans une voiture rouge.	He was seen in a red car.
On a falsifié les preuves.	The evidence has been falsified.
On n’accepte pas les remboursements.	Refunds aren’t accepted.
On a enregistré le vol sur la caméra.	The robbery was recorded on the camera.

With Commands and Instructions

Français	English
On y va !	Let's go!
On ne fait pas ça.	This is not how we do things. We don't do that.
On n'accepte pas ça.	This is unacceptable. We don't accept this.
On se calme !	Calm down!

Soi - Oneself

Soi is a stressed pronoun corresponding to "on" as a generic neutral subject.
What makes SOI unique is that it's used only for indefinite, unspecified persons; that is, when speaking in generalities and with indefinite pronouns and impersonal verbs.

Français	English
Chacun devrait penser pour **soi**.	Everyone should think for **themselves**.
Après la fête, chacun est rentré chez **soi**.	Everyone went back to their place.
Il faut avoir confiance en **soi**.	One must have confidence in **oneself**.
On le ferait pour **soi**.	**One** would do it for **oneself**.
Chacun pour soi.	**Everyone for himself.**

Soi-même - Oneself

It is an emphatic-stressed pronoun used to stress the actor/subject. It is used with reference to an indefinite pronoun or when no antecedent is expressed. There are a number of translations for soi-même:

- one/ oneself
- they/ themselves, itself

Français	English
On doit faire ses tâches **soi-même**.	**One** must do one's tasks **oneself**.
Tout le monde travaille pour **soi-même**.	Everyone works for **themselves**.
Aimer son prochain comme **soi-même**.	To love one's neighbour as **oneself**.